POLICY | AUTHORITIES AND REFERRALS

Fertiliser Recommendations in Sri Lanka: Who Decides, and Where to Refer Farmers

How paddy fertiliser recommendations are issued, which source takes precedence, and the named channels a farmer should be routed to.

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Teaching edition for the STEMLink AI Engineer Bootcamp. Content restructured from AgriVibe knowledge base AV-KB-001 Rev 1.1, which grounds its agronomy in Department of Agriculture and RRDI guidance for Sri Lanka. Not for use with real farmers until the verification items in AV-POL-03 are closed.

1. How recommendations are issued

The Department of Agriculture (DOA) does not issue one national fertiliser figure for paddy. Its recommendations are layered:

- by agro-ecological zone: the Wet Zone differs from the Intermediate and Dry Zone;
- by water regime: irrigated differs from rainfed;
- by varietal age class: three month, three and a half month or four month;
- by location: recommendations are published at Grama Niladhari (GN) division level, district by district;
- by field-specific refinements: soil analysis reports, soil test kit results and leaf colour index values.

2. Order of precedence

Table 1. Which source decides a quantity

1. Source: Grama Niladhari division fertiliser recommendation (DOA); Use: The authoritative source for quantities for a given field's location..
2. Source: The Agriculture Instructor for the area; Use: Applies the recommendation to the specific field, including soil and leaf colour checks..
3. Source: General DOA/RRDI zone and water regime schedules (AV-CG-06); Use: Orientation in time only. Never a quantity for a specific field..

Zinc sulphate is recommended once a year for rice. The DOA publishes four general schedules (Intermediate and Dry Zone, and Wet Zone, each irrigated and rainfed), held in AV-CG-06. The DOA also publishes soil test, soil analysis report and leaf colour index based recommendations, which refine the general schedules for a specific field.

3. Referral channels

Name a concrete channel rather than saying "consult a professional".

The Agriculture Instructor for the area

The Department of Agriculture field officer who can inspect the crop and give the recommendation that applies to that field.

The 1920 agricultural advisory service

The Department's free advisory short code, operating daily during office hours, where technical officers answer farming questions and departmental specialists handle complex technical issues. It is operated by the National Agriculture Information and Communication Centre (NAICC), which also provides the Krushi Advisor mobile application.

The Grama Niladhari division fertiliser recommendation

The authoritative source for quantities, published district by district.

A leaf colour chart check

The recognised field method for deciding whether a rice crop needs nitrogen. The Rice Research and Development Institute uses the chart in Sri Lanka, and the DOA publishes recommendations based on leaf colour index values.

4. Institutions

Department of Agriculture (DOA), Peradeniya: Issues fertiliser recommendations, including by GN division; employs Agriculture Instructors.
Rice Research and Development Institute (RRDI), Batalagoda, Kurunegala district: National centre for rice research; regional stations at Bombuwala, Ambalantota, Labuduwa, Bentota, Sammanthurei, Murunkan and Paranthan.
National Agriculture Information and Communication Centre (NAICC): Operates the 1920 advisory service and the Krushi Advisor application.